(Kiratli 2021), elite cues (Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023), limited knowledge (Rho and Tomz 2017; Dolan and Milner 2023), political ideology (Brutger and Clark 2022; von Borzyskowski and Vabulas 2024a), core values (Brutger 2021), and low levels of empathy (Casler and Groves 2023). Many states, such as those in the former Soviet bloc, Latin America, and others, have long questioned certain IOs' legitimacy and abilities to represent ordinary people. But while many detractors oppose specific facets of IOs (e.g., procedures, authority, or performance), most do not oppose international cooperation altogether. Those that do typically are not large enough in number or power to fundamentally threaten IOs. Populism, however, offers a popular and widespread ideology to explain why IOs should not constrain states, and thus represents a potent challenge (Voeten 2021).

Because many political ideologies and core values are compatible with populism, its appeal crosses party and ideological lines, boosting its popularity. Populism's congruence with other beliefs helps populists attract support at the ballot box relative to other skeptics of international cooperation. Thus, while our theory applies to many of globalization's detractors, we focus on populists as a particularly salient and prevalent set of actors who consistently oppose global governance (Ikenberry 2018; Voeten 2020; Broz, Frieden, and Weymouth 2021).

While populists differ on many dimensions, they share two defining characteristics: 1) a belief that a country's "true people" are locked into conflict with outsiders and elites, and 2) opposition to constraints on the will of the true people.[7] The meaning of "the true people" can vary based on context, but it generally refers to a perceived authentic, idealized majority that populist leaders claim to represent while excluding those who are seen as outsiders or part of the establishment. These true people are portrayed as good and hardworking, in contrast to corrupt elites. Populists claim they will provide power to these people at the expense of elites.[8]

Populists accuse IOs of standing in the way of this goal because IOs typically comprise elites and constrain national sovereignty. IOs are staffed by unelected, highly educated, lifelong bureaucrats who epitomize the global elites whom populists disparage. Such bureaucrats are rewarded for acquiring elite skills and experience—often receiving their education from top Western universities (Weaver 2008; Chwieroth 2015) and working for